

1st Annual Human-CAT (Connection, Animals, Technology) Interaction Meet-Up

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Figure 1: Various pets related to the organizers comprising different species, as well as both physical and digital pets.

Abstract

This meet-up focuses on the relationship between humans, pets, and technology. The first part of the meet-up will involve informal networking among pet owners of the HCI community, as well as anyone interested in discussing pets. In a group setting, participants will share their experiences of balancing pet ownership with academic responsibilities, offer advice for both current and prospective pet owners, and highlight the current needs of pets and how they can be addressed. The latter part of the meet-up will focus on design for pets. The organizers will first discuss prior HCI work in the area. Then, in breakout groups, participants will engage in rapid brainstorming to identify challenges in designing for their pets and develop ideas to address these gaps. At the end, attendees will have employed design thinking towards human-pet interaction, while

fostering a renewed appreciation for supporting and enriching the lives of their animal companions.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI.**

Keywords

human, pet, interaction, design, well-being, community

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1 Goal of the Meet-Up

We propose the first annual Human-CAT (*Connection, Animals, Technology*) Interaction meet-up. This meet-up aims to bring together researchers, students, and pet enthusiasts to explore how



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living with pets influences our daily lives and how technology can enhance these relationships. Based on our experiences, many graduate students, especially those studying abroad, often turn to pets for companionship and mental health support in the face of cultural differences and feelings of loneliness. Yet pets can also be demanding — needing attention and care while their human companions struggle to focus on deep, uninterrupted academic work — and they have specific living environment requirements that are not always easily met.

As HCI researchers, we often design technologies primarily for humans, but what if we designed for both humans and pets? Prior work has considered, for example, interspecies games that humans can play with their pets [2, 4, 5, 7], or ways to incorporate design into everyday living with pets [1, 3]. Research has also considered designing to support people’s emotional relationships with pets, from adoption [6] to bereavement [8, 9]. The global pet tech market size was estimated at USD 10.5 billion in 2023, including pet health tracking monitors, GPS trackers, pet toys, feeders, smart cameras, which aims to help the owners to better care for their pets¹.

In this meet-up, we will discuss how to design for pets and human to enhance joint happiness and life satisfaction. We will also explore how to design digital or robotic pets that can provide meaningful emotional support to humans. We highlight how design and HCI thinking can support human-pet interactions, and we hope that participants will leave with a renewed appreciation for their relationship with their pets, as well as consideration of ways to provide their pets with an enriched environment. This gathering is also an opportunity to share personal stories, make new friends, and collectively imagine how human-computer interaction can improve the human-pet life experiences.

2 Description of the Organizers

Our organizers bring a mix of academic backgrounds and pet ownership experiences:

- **Elise** — PhD student (1st-year) who adopted a 2-year-old seal-point cat named Hippo. Her research interests lie in computer-mediated communication. Hippo is a talkative cat who never produces a typical “meow”. Elise is exploring ways to understand better and interpret Hippo’s language. She is also interested in how pets impact human well-being, as living with Hippo has significantly improved her own mental health.
- **Michael** — PhD candidate (4th-year), and former parent to 2 cats, Po-po and Yuan-yuan. His research spans several branches — gamification, reflective technologies, and social relationships. He is interested in gamified design that encourages co-play between pets and humans. However, he is also interested in the emotional aftermath of pet bereavement and how humans reflect near the end of their pet’s life.
- **Xincheng** — PhD student (5th-year), a parent to a digital pet frog, with an interest in owning a living pet. His neighbour owns cats and a chicken. His research primarily focuses on telepresence in mixed reality. For humans and pets, he is interested in creating shared virtual environments that can

promote closeness and interactivity between humans and their pets, even when the relationship is long-distance.

- **Preeti** — PhD candidate (6th year) studying the role of zoomorphic robots in emotion regulation. Her research intersects psychology, haptics, and human–robot interaction, focusing on how touch-based technologies can support emotion regulation. Currently, she explores how zoomorphic appearance, form, and biomimetic behaviours can enhance haptic robots. She frequently hangs out with the neighbourhood kitty, Mitze.
- **Angela** — Undergraduate research assistant (3rd year), and current walker of 2 dogs. Her research interests include understanding social relationships, with a particular focus on the relationships between humans and their pets. She also has extensive experience organizing meet-ups as part of her club and job.
- **Robert** — Professor at the University of British Columbia and faculty sponsor of the meet-up; former caretaker of a Bichon Frisé dog and two hamsters.

3 Activities of the Meet-Up

The meet-up will include following activities in the 90-minute period:

Topic	Time	Details
Welcome & Introductions	20 min	In an informal networking session, participants introduce themselves and their pets, sharing photos or short stories. Snacks and drinks will be provided by the organizers.
Small Group Discussions	15 min	Attendees split into groups of 4–10. Groups discuss what their pets bring to their lives and the challenges of living with them. For those interested in digital or robotic pets, the discussion will focus on how these companions provide emotional support and what additional features participants wish such pets could offer.
Technology Brainstorm	30 min	Participants explore and develop ideas on how technological design could address challenges or enhance human–pet relationships.
Group Sharing	15 min	Each group nominates a representative to summarize and share their discussion highlights and ideas with all attendees. Participants can vote on ideas they like, and groups with the most votes will get small prizes.
Closing & Pet Stickers	10 min	To wrap up, attendees can print a free custom sticker of their pet alongside the CHI 2026 logo as a fun takeaway.

Table 1: Planned activities for the 90-minute Human–CAT Interaction meetup.

¹<https://www.gminsights.com/industry-analysis/pet-tech-market>

4 Who Would Be Interested?

Although the meet-up is open to all attendees, we envision that specific communities of interest would be:

- **Pet owners in academia who want to meet and make friends:** Pet owners of all types of pets, including robot/digital pets, will have the opportunity to network and share their experiences. They will also have an opportunity to speculate on and understand how technology can support their own pets' needs.
- **Non-pet owners who are interested in pets and want to learn more:** Even for attendees who do not own pets, our meet-up serves as an opportunity to make friends, hear about individual pet experiences, explore the impact of pets on personal and academic life, and learn more about the emerging field of human-pet interaction.
- **Academics with interest in human-pet interaction research:** This meet-up will be a prime opportunity for academics who currently work, or want to work, in the human-pet interaction area to form a network of connections with people who have pets and better understand their needs and goals. This meet-up will help crystallize initial ideas, which can develop into potential collaborative research projects in the future.

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